

No theory, Just a Task

A Regime Theory of Joy

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How to Reduce Monitoring

Checking

We can observe that checking is sometimes absurd. The clearest example occurs when we lock the front door. We often go back to make sure that it is “properly locked.” There may be security reasons for doing so, of course, yet most of us cannot recall a single occasion when we thought, “Good thing I checked, it really was unlocked.”



We all recognize this behavior as irrational. What is less obvious is that the same behavior occurs constantly. Suppose I put a glass on a table. It may seem that no checking has taken place, but it was simply so fast that it never entered conscious awareness.

The automatic checks include: “Is this really a sensible place to put the glass?” or “Is it too close to the edge?” All of this happens within milliseconds.



At times, moving an object, looking at something only once, or aligning two objects without checking afterward can relax monitoring, provided that it does not become a method, which would add anticipation and verification to the exercise itself.



The general mentality of all exercises is “Short and only once or twice”. Verifying is a major source of monitoring, and repetition increases it, as much as it increases planning. This is also why they should be done sparsely.

Comparison

Comparison is an activity we engage in from morning to night. Comparing two routes or two sidewalks to optimize comfort is rarely very important. More fundamentally, we can choose and act *without genuinely comparing*, just as we can pursue a mission locally without entering mission mode.

There are several forms of comparison: comparing options to identify the best choice, comparing before and after to *verify* a result, and comparing *importance or value*.

Some objects are automatically ranked highly for philosophical or cultural reasons, not just for monetary value. A book placed on a table among ordinary objects, for example, immediately stands out and receives a favorable ranking, perhaps even acquiring a sacred quality, since books symbolize knowledge. A simple exercise would be to briefly equalize the importance of the book and the surrounding objects. The aim is not to keep them permanently equal, but to create a momentary breach.



You can equalize almost everything. Any item, paths, or options. But it must remain brief and rare.



Decentering: The “One Among Many” Concept. An object can be seen as “one among many”, rather than as something “sacred”. In the same way, a small action can remain just one action among many. Even a place. As always, the shift should be brief.

Imagination

We naturally think of imagination in positive terms, associating it with dreams. It also allows us to anticipate the future and find ways out of problems. This form is highly visible: we can consciously reflect on possible scenarios for as long as we wish.

Yet imagination, like checking, also operates continuously. It may be directed toward the future, as a vague sense that many scenarios remain possible, or toward the surrounding space, through the constant mental representation of what might exist or happen around us. In this way, imagination can contribute to an ongoing attempt to maintain control over both the future and the environment: this is, again, the monitoring process.

We can recognize that, in some situations, refraining from generating scenarios has no serious consequences, particularly when those scenarios concern our spatial

environment. Is it really necessary to imagine possibilities involving the next street we might take, or the history of every object we encounter?



At times, you can refrain from extending your imagination by leaving unimagined what might be happening behind a door, beyond a window, or on the other side of an obstacle.



Something appears. Briefly and sparsely, there is nothing you need to feel. It is the “**What appears, appears**” exercise. Illustration: You open a drawer: What appears, appears. More largely, you open or glare at something: **What appears, appears.**

Importance

Importance must be justified for monitoring to become active. A luxury car, for example, is perceived as important and activates judgments of value and appropriate behavior: a luxury object should be preserved, whereas a useless object may be easily discarded.

Objects are therefore categorized primarily according to their value. Monitoring remains active when importance, value, or rarity is justified. Gold, for instance, is rare because its supply is limited, precious because it is useful for particular purposes, and expensive because its market price is high. Perceiving gold as precious for these reasons therefore reinforces monitoring.

One solution is to equalize, as seen before, and another, more direct one, is to highly value an ordinary detail.



Sometimes, notice an useless or ordinary detail and artificially increase its ranking. For example, look at a shadow, and label it as important. It must remain brief. Let the importance fades away normally immediately.

Sometimes, for a brief moment, everything in the scene can be equally relevant.

Mission Mode

Having a project is a good thing, but developing “main character syndrome,” that is, treating the project like a television miniseries with a past, a present, and a future, is an excellent way to increase monitoring.

Children have projects all the time, but before secondary school, they generally do not frame them in this way. A project remains local to the classroom, and each break is a genuine break during which the project is completely suspended. Then the break ends and

is itself suspended, almost as if it had never happened.



In childhood, recess are self-sufficient and expendable

Mission mode should be avoided. I, for example, have a mission, but I am not in mission mode. I am trying to show that something genuinely positive exists, namely joy. For that, you need to transition into the right brain regime, so you pass the word, but it remains a local project.



Avoid self-congratulation, such as “I am pleased with the result,” “I am proud of this,” or “This is going to turn out well.” Make progress, without *viewing it* as progress all the time.



Exercises should not be scheduled for particular situations, especially stressful ones. Doing so reintroduces monitoring: you begin watching for situation X or Y so that you can apply the exercise when it occurs.

Thoughts

Thoughts are undoubtedly the most difficult subject. There is what is known as the ironic process by Daniel Wegner: the more we try to suppress a thought, the more persistently it returns, leaving us resigned to our inability to control this mental machinery. In the Ease framework, however, the problem lies not in the thoughts themselves, but in the felt necessity to produce a continuation.

Z-reduction tasks can therefore be based on thoughts: think of a word once without returning to it, or imagine an object once and then allow its image to disappear.



At the end of thought, even a positive one, occasionally add 3 unrelated words, such as “spoon, cloud, giraffe”, to curb the next action pressure.

Narratives

As we have seen, some experiences feel positive, while still increasing monitoring. They may initially produce satisfaction, but satisfaction is not joy. More broadly, what increases action pressure and evaluation belongs to what we commonly call the adult world.

Even when an experience is positive, it often remains evaluative. Remember that, within the Ease framework, entry into joy does not tolerate evaluation, even positive evaluation, because it still constitutes monitoring.

Humor provides one example. It is usually organized around responsibility, judgment, social norms, or their violation. Only humor that is genuinely absurd and local is able to remain compatible with joy, and this form is found especially in cartoons, particularly older ones.

Simply following a story can have a similar effect. As discussed in relation to mission mode and television-series thinking, a story may be mildly enjoyable while keeping evaluative monitoring fully active: anticipating, imagining, checking, comparing characters, and waiting for what comes next. Long-running series are perhaps the clearest example.



Narrative forms of entertainment are typically monitoring-heavy, even when they are interesting, intellectually engaging, or enjoyable in their own right. Games, books, films, and documentaries can be rewarding without being compatible with the state. Music and music videos may remain compatible because they do not require following a continuous story.



A possible exercise is to very briefly read some lines of any book in an unordered manner, without trying to extract meaning.

Next action

There is usually a next action. Even in secondary school, when one class ends, it is time to prepare for another. Each day becomes an uninterrupted sequence of small tasks, with joy confined to the spaces between them. We can act on this sense of continuous obligation by noticing where monitoring is taking place. Sometimes that alone is enough to lower it: we mentally pause briefly and the current task no longer has to lead immediately to the next.



Sometimes, briefly let the next action remain undecided.
Sometimes, briefly let one action be enough.

Maintaining preferences

It is helpful to avoid preferences that take the form “Once I get to that place, or find myself in that situation, it will be good.” For example, having a favourite place and becoming convinced that joy depends on being there can immediately increase monitoring through comparison and positive anticipation. Looking forward to it may itself be pleasant, but within the Regime Theory of Joy, that pleasure keeps monitoring active and obscures the more intense joy that may emerge when monitoring falls sufficiently.



There are no specific exercises, but one needs to let go of the preferences. It is not easy because it is also rewarding at times, but it is a major source of monitoring. Treat having preferences as *non-sense or illusion*: Many people don't know your favourite places, yet do have positive affect.

Valuing something, including joy

When we do something that interests us, we attend to what matters in that situation. Comparison becomes highly active, and each relevant detail acquires importance. Sometimes joy itself becomes important: we try to preserve it, and that effort hastens its decline. Think of a song or a patch of sunlight that you try to hold on to, only for the beginnings of joy to collapse thirty seconds later instead of growing.

Two things matter here: avoid assigning special value to the state, and sometimes even interrupt it deliberately, for example by stopping a song just as you begin to enjoy it.

Adults who have experienced the ease regime know that interrupting the experience at its peak is difficult. But, thoughts such as "This is wonderful, it has to continue" or "This is clearly the only positive thing" increase perceived value and evaluation, causing the peak to collapse rather than sustaining it.



Briefly see a video you like as simply an MP4 file.

Briefly notice one visual detail that is irrelevant to what you are doing.

Those 2 exercises will collapse joy, which is something that must be tolerated.

Social Life

Apart from local, purposeless playground games, social life tends to involve a considerable amount of monitoring. Its intensity depends on the context, but consider a few simple and common situations: waiting for someone, having an appointment, searching for arguments, trying to be relevant or funny, attempting to project a particular image through good posture, talking about oneself, which forces a return to main-character thinking, or anticipating and imagining other people's reactions in order to prepare a better response.



A photograph permits affect *without* requiring an immediate social evaluation. Because no response is expected from the viewer, monitoring can briefly recede, allowing the affective signal to develop.

All of this is naturally monitoring-heavy. Within the Ease framework, joy emerges only during moments when monitoring and evaluative pressure, even positive evaluative pressure, decrease. Trying to compensate by inserting Z-reduction exercises into these situations is not recommended. Sometimes it is better to enter the optimization regime fully than to struggle against it.



Monitoring-heavy, unavoidable moments must not be something to fight against, as it will re-introduce monitoring even more. Keep separate Z-reduction tasks away from them. Just as children separate recess.

News and other forms of content

In the media, especially the news, two processes maintain monitoring: questions left open through clickbait, and the need to form positions toward the people presented. The first is straightforward. News headlines often avoid answering the subject directly and instead open an implicit question. For example: “LIVE. White House meeting: the president will speak after meeting with party leaders.” Reading this immediately raises questions such as “Why?”, “When?”, and “With whom?”, because the relevant information has been carefully withheld from the headline. Monitoring is therefore activated at on.

After clicking, we encounter public figures whom monitoring attempts to classify as likable or unlikable, good or bad, or as belonging to one category or another.



Sometimes, notice a character and don't decide if you like him or not. Sometimes, read a news title and don't treat it as a question that needs an answer.

Within a Video Game (2-3 minutes)

The idea is to play without trying to win. By doing so in the game, it expands to the Z exercises. In a first-person shooter, if someone fires at you, you might defend yourself a little, or sometimes not at all. It does not matter.



From time to time, briefly do one exercise within the game: act without checking the result (eg: changing direction), treat two paths as equally relevant, finish a thought with three absurd words, or make a single small movement. Leave some space between exercises, perhaps thirty seconds, so that the session does not acquire a sense of speed or a demand for perfect execution.



One good candidate is unreal tournament 1999: When HUD is off and the enemies are set to a low level, there is nothing optimized. In deathmatch, it is meaningless and stupid, characteristics compatible with joy.

References

Florian Morin proposes that joy is gated by evaluative monitoring: joy does not simply fade, it becomes inaccessible when monitoring and optimization remain active.

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